The Turks occupied Delhi and then embarked on a series of conquests that radically changed the political, social and urban geography of India. By 1194, Varanasi and Kannauj were captured and sacked. The latter, then the largest city in northern India, would never really recover. Within a few years, the university of Nalanda was destroyed by Bakhtiyar Khilji, its library was torched and most of its scholars put to death. The scene was chronicled by Minhaj-ud-din, a judge from Ghor, who had accompanied the invading army:

> The great number of the inhabitants of that place were Brahmans … and they were all slain. There were a great number of books there; and when all these books came under the observation of the Mussalmans they summoned a number of Hindus that they might give them information respecting the import of these books; but the whole of the Hindus had been killed … [13]

While there were many Brahmin scholars at Nalanda, the bulk of those massacred were probably Buddhist monks. A few survivors would linger, but most would flee to Tibet where their traditions would be kept alive till the Chinese take-over of the mid-twentieth century. After Nalanda, Bakhtiyar Khilji attacked and completely destroyed Vikramshila, another famous Buddhist university. The practice of Buddhism in the subcontinent, already in decline, would collapse after these devastating attacks. In 1235, Sultan Iltutmish laid waste Ujjain—once the secondary capital of the Gupta empire and a major centre for mathematics, literature, astronomy and Hindu philosophy. It is worth noting that at exactly the same time as these universities were being destroyed, the University of Oxford was being established on the other side of the planet.

By the end of the thirteenth century, armies led by generals like Malik Kafur would be making raids into the deep south. It was a very bloody period in Indian history—ancient cities, universities and temples were laid waste and hundreds of thousands, probably millions, were massacred. Anyone who doubts this should read the *Tarikh-i-Farishtah* [14] . Thus ended the second cycle of urbanization that had begun in the Gangetic plains during the Iron Age.